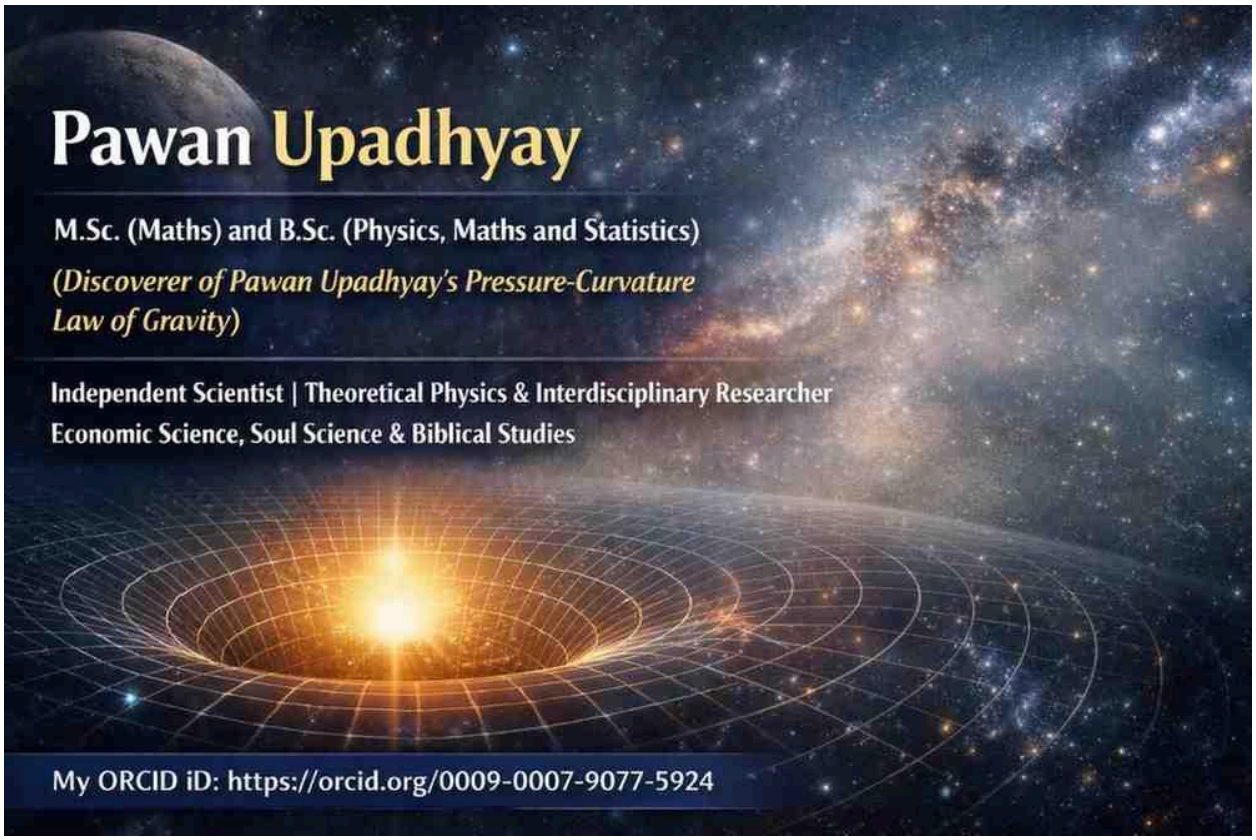
Psalm 1:1 — A Research Study of the Blessed and Virtuous Person

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Abstract

Psalm 1:1 introduces the Psalter with a description of the person who is called **blessed**. Rather than beginning with material prosperity or worldly success, the psalm defines blessedness through a person's relationship to God, his choices, his associations, and his response to ungodly influence. The verse describes three things the blessed person refuses: **the counsel of the ungodly, the way of sinners, and the seat of mockers**.

This study examines Psalm 1:1 through the Douay-Rheims translation and the underlying Hebrew vocabulary. Particular attention is given to the Hebrew **אַשְׁרֵי (*'ashrê*)**, the progression of **walking, standing, and sitting**, and the movement from **counsel to conduct to settled association**. The study also considers the spiritual implications of ungodly influence, purity of thought, humility, speech, discernment, and the biblical contrast between the way of the righteous and the way of the wicked.

The central argument is that Psalm 1:1 presents blessedness as a way of life characterized by **spiritual discernment, separation from sinful influence, commitment to righteousness, and preparation for delight in God's law**. The verse does not merely teach the avoidance of bad behavior; it presents a model of a person who deliberately guards the direction of his mind, conduct, and fellowship.

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1. Introduction

Psalm 1 serves as an entrance into the Book of Psalms. It presents two contrasting ways of life: the **way of the righteous** and the **way of the wicked**.

The opening verse states:

“Blessed is the man who hath not walked in the counsel of the ungodly, nor stood in the way of sinners, nor sat in the chair of pestilence.”
— Psalm 1:1, Douay-Rheims

The verse immediately raises an important question:

What makes a person blessed?

The answer begins negatively. The blessed person is identified by what he **does not allow to govern his life**.

He does not:

1. walk in the counsel of the ungodly;
2. stand in the way of sinners;
3. sit in the chair of pestilence or among mockers.

This structure suggests that a person's spiritual life is deeply connected with **the counsel he accepts, the path he follows, and the company in which he becomes settled**.

Psalm 1:1 therefore provides a foundational study of spiritual discernment.

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2. Text of Psalm 1:1

The Douay-Rheims translation reads:

“Blessed is the man who hath not walked in the counsel of the ungodly, nor stood in the way of sinners, nor sat in the chair of pestilence.”

The verse contains several important concepts:

- Blessed
- Man/person
- Walked
- Counsel
- Ungodly
- Stood
- Way
- Sinners
- Sat
- Chair/seat
- Pestilence/mockers

Each contributes to the theological message of the verse.

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3. The Meaning of “Blessed”

The Hebrew expression translated **“Blessed”** in Psalm 1:1 is:

אַשְׁרֵי

’ashrê

It is associated with the Hebrew root **אשר (*ʾ-sh-r*)**.

The expression conveys ideas such as:

- blessedness;
- happiness;
- fortunate condition;
- well-being.

It is important to distinguish *’ashrê* from the Hebrew verb:

בָּרַךְ

bārak

which means **“to bless.”**

Thus Psalm 1:1 does not simply say:

“God blessed the man.”

Rather, it announces the blessed or fortunate condition of the person being described.

A useful interpretive rendering is:

“How blessed is the person who does not walk in the counsel of the ungodly…”

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4. Blessedness Is a Spiritual Condition

Biblical blessedness should not be reduced to wealth, comfort, popularity, or worldly success.

A person can experience hardship and still be described as blessed.

Psalm 1 connects blessedness primarily with the **direction of one's life before God**.

The blessed person:

- rejects ungodly counsel;
- refuses the way of sinners;
- avoids settling among mockers;
- delights in God's law;
- meditates upon God's law.

Thus blessedness is closely connected with **relationship, righteousness, wisdom, and obedience**.

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5. “The Counsel of the Ungodly”

The first danger identified in the verse is:

“the counsel of the ungodly.”

Counsel means advice, guidance, instruction, or a way of thinking that influences decisions.

The ungodly person is one who does not order life according to God.

Therefore, ungodly counsel can be understood as guidance that is contrary to God's righteousness.

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6. Ungodly Counsel Can Misguide

People constantly receive advice.

We receive counsel from:

- friends;
- family;
- teachers;
- colleagues;
- media;
- entertainment;
- social networks;
- cultural influences;
- religious and philosophical teachers.

Not every source of advice is equally trustworthy.

The virtuous person therefore exercises discernment.

He does not accept advice simply because:

- it is popular;
- it sounds intelligent;
- many people believe it;
- it promises immediate pleasure;
- it makes life easier.

Instead, he asks:

Does this counsel agree with God's truth?

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7. The Danger of Misguidance

Wrong counsel can influence a person's thinking.

Thinking influences decisions.

Decisions produce actions.

Repeated actions can become habits.

Habits can shape character.

Therefore:

Counsel can influence the direction of a person's life.

This explains why Psalm 1 begins with counsel.

The danger of sin does not always begin with an obvious sinful action.

It can begin with accepting a false idea.

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8. A Spiritual Illustration: Sin as a Virus

Sin can be illustrated as being like a **virus in a system**.

A computer virus can enter a system and interfere with its normal operation.

Similarly, persistent sinful thinking can corrupt a person's:

- thoughts;
- desires;
- decisions;
- habits;
- relationships;
- speech;
- behavior.

This is an illustration rather than a literal description of sin.

The purpose of the illustration is to show how **wrong influence can progressively affect the whole person**.

A false idea that is repeatedly accepted can eventually influence behavior.

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9. Purity of Thought

The virtuous person therefore seeks **purity of thought**.

He understands that the mind is an important part of moral and spiritual life.

What a person repeatedly entertains can influence what he eventually chooses.

The virtuous person therefore seeks to fill his mind with things consistent with truth and righteousness.

This prepares for Psalm 1:2, where the righteous person's delight is in the law of the LORD.

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10. “Nor Stood in the Way of Sinners”

The second expression is:

“nor stood in the way of sinners.”

The imagery changes from **counsel** to **way**.

Counsel concerns direction and thought.

Way concerns conduct and lifestyle.

The sinner is no longer merely giving advice.

The person is now standing in the sinner's way.

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11. The Way Represents a Direction

A way or road leads somewhere.

Biblical writers frequently use “way” as a metaphor for a person's manner of life.

Psalm 1 ultimately contrasts:

the way of the just

with:

the way of the wicked.

Therefore, “the way of sinners” represents a direction of life characterized by sinful conduct.

The virtuous person refuses to make that path his own.

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12. Sin Has Consequences

The biblical understanding of sin includes consequences.

Sin damages the relationship between the human person and God.

Scripture also teaches that unrepentant sin leads to judgment.

Therefore, the way of sinners is not merely an alternative lifestyle with no consequences.

The virtuous person recognizes that choices have destinations.

He therefore asks:

Where will this way lead?

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13. The Virtuous Person Does Not Follow the Crowd

The virtuous person does not determine right and wrong simply by popularity.

A practice does not become righteous merely because many people participate in it.

Likewise, something does not become true simply because it is widely accepted.

The virtuous person seeks a higher standard:

the truth and commandments of God.

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14. “Nor Sat in the Chair of Pestilence”

The final expression in the Douay-Rheims is:

“nor sat in the chair of pestilence.”

Other translations commonly use expressions such as:

“seat of scoffers”

or

“seat of the scornful.”

The image is significant.

The person is no longer merely walking or standing.

He is **sitting**.

He has become settled.

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15. The Meaning of Mockery

A mocker ridicules or treats something with contempt.

In the context of Psalm 1, the image concerns those who reject or ridicule righteousness.

Mockers may ridicule:

- faith;
- prayer;
- Scripture;
- holiness;
- obedience;
- repentance;
- devotion to God.

The virtuous person does not allow such mockery to become the atmosphere in which he settles.

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16. Mockers Can Attack Faith

A person who sincerely follows God may sometimes experience ridicule.

Others may say:

“Why do you take your faith so seriously?”

or:

“Everyone does this. Why don't you?”

or:

“Your beliefs are outdated.”

Such statements can pressure a person to compromise.

Psalm 1 presents the blessed person as someone who refuses to allow mockery to determine his faithfulness.

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17. Humility and the Virtuous Person

The virtuous person is not described as proud or self-righteous.

True virtue is compatible with **humility**.

A humble person recognizes:

- dependence upon God;
- personal limitations;
- the need for wisdom;
- the possibility of being corrected;
- the seriousness of sin.

Humility is therefore an important protection against both sin and pride.

The virtuous person does not say:

“I am better than everyone else.”

Instead, he seeks to say:

“I need God's wisdom and grace to walk rightly.”

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18. Humble Speech

The virtuous person also seeks to speak with humility.

His words should not be characterized by:

- arrogance;
- contempt;
- unnecessary insult;
- humiliation of others;
- boastfulness.

Humility in speech reflects humility of heart.

The virtuous person understands that words have power.

They can:

- encourage;
- correct;
- comfort;
- teach;
- heal.

But they can also:

- wound;
- deceive;
- humiliate;
- provoke;
- destroy relationships.

Therefore, the virtuous person seeks to speak truth with wisdom and humility.

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19. The Progression: Walk, Stand, Sit

One of the most important observations in Psalm 1:1 is the progression:

Walk → Stand → Sit

This can be interpreted as a literary picture of increasing involvement.

Walk

“walked in the counsel of the ungodly”

The person is exposed to ungodly thinking.

Stand

“stood in the way of sinners”

The person becomes associated with sinful conduct.

Sit

“sat in the chair of pestilence”

The person becomes settled among those who ridicule or reject righteousness.

The progression can therefore be summarized:

Influence → Participation → Identification

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20. Counsel, Way, and Seat

The three nouns reinforce the progression:

Stage	Expression	Spiritual area
1	Counsel	Thinking
2	Way	Conduct
3	Seat	Fellowship/settlement

The movement is from the **mind** to **behavior** to **social identification**.

This makes Psalm 1:1 a profound study of spiritual influence.

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21. The Virtuous Person Guards His Mind

The first line teaches the importance of guarding one's thinking.

If wrong counsel is continually accepted, it can alter one's understanding of right and wrong.

Therefore, spiritual protection begins with discernment.

The virtuous person asks:

“Is this counsel true?”

“Is this consistent with Scripture?”

“What kind of person will this advice make me?”

“Where will following this counsel lead?”

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22. The Virtuous Person Guards His Conduct

The second line moves from thought to action.

It is not enough to know what is right.

The virtuous person must also **walk in the right way**.

He therefore refuses to adopt sinful patterns merely because they are common or socially accepted.

His goal is righteousness rather than conformity.

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23. The Virtuous Person Guards His Fellowship

The third line concerns where the person becomes settled.

The virtuous person understands that companionship can influence character.

This does not mean that he must avoid all contact with sinners.

Rather, it means that he does not make sinful attitudes and mockery the defining environment of his life.

He can show compassion toward sinners without adopting their sin.

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24. Separation Does Not Mean Hatred

A crucial distinction should be made.

The virtuous person may separate himself from **sinful influence** without hating sinners.

Biblical righteousness includes compassion, mercy, forgiveness, and love.

The goal is not:

“I am better than you.”

The goal is:

“I will not allow sin to become the pattern of my life.”

This is an important difference between **holiness and self-righteousness**.

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25. The Positive Alternative: Psalm 1:2

Psalm 1:1 tells us what the blessed person rejects.

Psalm 1:2 tells us what he embraces:

“But his will is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he shall meditate day and night.”

The word **“But”** creates a contrast.

The virtuous person does not merely empty his life of ungodly influences.

He fills his life with God's Word.

This gives us a positive pattern:

Reject ungodly counsel → delight in God's law.

Reject the way of sinners → walk in righteousness.

Reject the seat of mockers → meditate upon God's Word.

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26. God's Word as the Source of Direction

If ungodly counsel can mislead, God's Word provides a righteous standard.

The virtuous person therefore needs more than avoidance.

He needs **truth**.

He needs wisdom.

He needs instruction.

He needs continual meditation.

Psalm 1:2 therefore provides the necessary counterpart to verse 1.

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27. From Counsel to Meditation

There is an important contrast:

Ungodly counsel

External voices attempt to shape the person's thinking.

Meditation on God's law

The person deliberately fills his mind with God's instruction.

The issue is therefore not whether the mind will be influenced.

The mind will be influenced.

The question is:

What will influence it?

Psalm 1 answers:

The law of the LORD.

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28. The Tree as the Result

Psalm 1:3 describes the result:

“And he shall be like a tree which is planted near the running waters…”

The tree provides a picture of:

- rootedness;
- stability;
- nourishment;
- fruitfulness;
- endurance.

The virtuous person becomes spiritually stable because he is rooted in God's Word.

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29. Fruitfulness

The tree eventually:

“bring[s] forth its fruit, in due season.”

This indicates that righteousness should produce visible results.

A person who continually receives God's truth should increasingly display:

- wisdom;
- humility;
- righteousness;
- patience;
- faithfulness;
- love;
- self-control;
- compassion.

The blessed life is therefore not merely a life of avoidance.

It is a life of **fruitfulness**.

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30. A Practical Model from Psalm 1:1

Psalm 1:1 can be applied through three questions.

Question 1 — Counsel

Whose advice am I allowing to shape my thinking?

Question 2 — Way

What path are my repeated decisions creating?

Question 3 — Seat

Where have I become comfortable and settled?

These questions can expose spiritual compromise before it becomes deeply rooted.

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31. A Model of Spiritual Protection

The teaching of Psalm 1:1 can be summarized as:

Guard the mind

Do not accept ungodly counsel without discernment.

Guard the path

Do not follow sinful practices.

Guard the fellowship

Do not settle among those who mock righteousness.

Fill the mind with God's Word

Delight in and meditate upon God's law.

Produce righteous fruit

Allow God's truth to shape conduct and character.

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32. The Two Ways

Psalm 1 ultimately presents two ways.

The way of the righteous

- God's law;
- meditation;
- stability;
- fruitfulness;
- divine knowledge.

The way of the wicked

- ungodly counsel;
- sinful conduct;
- mockery;
- instability;
- destruction.

Psalm 1:6 concludes:

“For the Lord knoweth the way of the just: and the way of the wicked shall perish.”

The entire psalm therefore revolves around a fundamental choice:

Which way will a person follow?

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33. Theological Synthesis

Psalm 1:1 teaches several interconnected truths.

1. Influence matters

What a person listens to can influence his thinking.

2. Thinking influences conduct

Accepted ideas can become decisions and actions.

3. Conduct can become a way of life

Repeated actions can become patterns.

4. Fellowship can reinforce behavior

The environments in which people settle can strengthen their values.

5. Sin has consequences

The way of wickedness ultimately leads to judgment.

6. Righteousness requires discernment

The virtuous person must distinguish between truth and error.

7. Humility is essential

The virtuous person depends upon God's wisdom rather than trusting his own understanding.

8. God's Word provides the positive foundation

Psalm 1:2 directs the blessed person toward the law of the LORD.

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34. Conclusion

Psalm 1:1 is a profound introduction to the biblical concept of the **blessed and virtuous person**.

The verse begins:

“Blessed is the man…”

and then describes what that person refuses.

He does not walk in:

the counsel of the ungodly.

He does not stand in:

the way of sinners.

He does not sit in:

the chair of pestilence.

The progression is:

Walk → Stand → Sit

and the corresponding spiritual movement may be understood as:

Counsel → Conduct → Settlement

or:

Influence → Participation → Identification.

The virtuous person therefore guards his mind, his conduct, and his fellowship.

He does not permit ungodly counsel to misguide him.

He does not follow the path of sinners.

He does not allow mockers to weaken his faith.

He seeks purity of thought, humility of character, and humility of speech.

The illustration of sin as a **virus** helps communicate the danger of allowing corrupting ideas to enter and influence the mind. Just as a virus can interfere with the functioning of a system,

persistent sinful influence can distort thinking and eventually affect behavior. Yet the biblical solution is not merely isolation. It is replacement.

Psalm 1:2 supplies that replacement:

The virtuous person delights in the law of the LORD and meditates upon it day and night.

Thus Psalm 1 presents a complete spiritual pattern:

Reject ungodly counsel.
Reject the way of sin.
Reject the influence of mockery.
Embrace God's Word.
Meditate upon His truth.
Walk in righteousness.
Bear fruit.

The blessed person is ultimately compared with a tree planted beside living waters.

His strength does not come merely from avoiding what is wrong.

His strength comes from being **rooted in what is right**.

The central lesson of Psalm 1:1 can therefore be stated:

A virtuous person carefully guards his mind from ungodly counsel, his life from the way of sinners, and his faith from the influence of mockers; instead, he turns toward God's truth and prepares himself to live a fruitful and righteous life.

Psalm 1:1 is therefore not merely a warning against bad company.

It is an invitation to choose the **blessed way**.

Psalm 1:1 — The Blessed Life

Guarding Yourself from Ungodly Counsel, the Way of Sinners, and the Company of Mockers

“Blessed is the man who hath not walked in the counsel of the ungodly, nor stood in the way of sinners, nor sat in the chair of pestilence.”
— Psalm 1:1, Douay-Rheims

Psalm 1 begins with a powerful declaration:

“Blessed is the man…”

Before explaining what the blessed person does, the psalm first tells us what he **does not do**.

The virtuous person understands that the people around him can influence his **thoughts, decisions, behavior, values, and ultimately his spiritual direction**. Therefore, he carefully guards himself against ungodly counsel, the way of sinners, and the influence of mockers.

Psalm 1:1 presents three stages:

Counsel → Way → Seat

Or, in the language of the verbs:

Walk → Stand → Sit

This progression provides a profound picture of how sinful influence can gradually enter a person's life.

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1. “Blessed Is the Man”

The first word is:

“Blessed”

The Hebrew word is **אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)**.

It expresses the idea of blessedness, happiness, fortunate condition, or well-being.

Psalm 1 is therefore describing the person who is truly **blessed before God**.

This blessedness is not merely about possessing money, success, comfort, or worldly achievements.

The psalm immediately defines the blessed person by his **relationship to God's way**.

He does not allow ungodliness to determine his thinking.

He does not follow the path of sinners.

He does not settle among those who mock righteousness.

His blessedness is connected with the direction of his life.

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2. “Who Hath Not Walked in the Counsel of the Ungodly”

The first warning concerns **counsel**.

“Who hath not walked in the counsel of the ungodly…”

Counsel concerns **advice, guidance, opinions, recommendations, and ways of thinking**.

People constantly receive counsel.

We receive counsel from:

- family;
- friends;
- teachers;
- coworkers;
- society;
- books;
- media;
- entertainment;
- social networks;
- religious teachers;
- intellectual influences.

Some counsel can lead us toward wisdom.

Other counsel can lead us away from God.

Psalm 1 warns the virtuous person not to allow **ungodly counsel** to direct his life.

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3. What Is Ungodly Counsel?

Ungodly counsel is advice or guidance that is contrary to God's truth and righteousness.

An ungodly person may say:

“There is nothing wrong with this.”

Or:

“Everyone does it.”

Or:

“You should do whatever makes you happy.”

Or:

“You don't need to obey God's commandments.”

Such advice may sound attractive, reasonable, modern, or convenient.

But the virtuous person does not judge counsel merely by how attractive it sounds.

He asks:

Does this agree with God's truth?

That is an important principle of spiritual discernment.

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4. Ungodly People Can Misguide the Virtuous Person

The danger is not necessarily that every ungodly person is openly hostile toward the virtuous person.

Sometimes wrong counsel can come through people who appear friendly.

A person may sincerely give advice and still give **wrong advice**.

Therefore, the virtuous person must not blindly accept advice simply because:

- the person is confident;
- the person is popular;
- the person is successful;
- the person is educated;
- many people agree with him.

The standard must ultimately be God's truth.

The virtuous person asks:

“Where will this counsel lead me?”

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5. Counsel Determines Direction

Advice influences decisions.

Decisions influence actions.

Actions form habits.

Habits shape character.

Character influences the direction of a person's life.

Therefore:

Counsel matters.

A person who repeatedly listens to ungodly counsel can gradually begin thinking according to that counsel.

What once seemed wrong may eventually seem normal.

What once troubled the conscience may eventually become acceptable.

This is why Psalm 1 begins by warning about **counsel**.

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6. “Nor Stood in the Way of Sinners”

The second warning moves from **counsel to conduct**:

“Nor stood in the way of sinners…”

The word **“way”** is important.

A way is a path.

A path represents a direction.

A person who follows a path is moving toward a destination.

Psalm 1 therefore presents sin as more than isolated actions.

It can become a **way of life**.

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7. The Way of Sinners

The “way of sinners” represents a path that is contrary to God's righteousness.

Sin may begin with a single choice.

But repeated sinful choices can become habits.

Habits can become patterns.

Patterns can become a way of life.

This is why the virtuous person does not merely avoid individual sinful acts; he refuses to **stand in the way of sinners**.

He does not choose their path as his path.

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8. Sin Has a Destination

A road has a destination.

Psalm 1 contrasts two ways:

the way of the righteous

and

the way of the wicked.

The psalm ultimately says:

“For the Lord knoweth the way of the just: and the way of the wicked shall perish.”
— Psalm 1:6

Therefore, the issue is not simply:

“What am I doing today?”

The deeper question is:

“Where is this path taking me?”

The virtuous person considers the destination before choosing the road.

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9. Sin and Judgment

Scripture teaches that sin ultimately leads to **judgment**.

The Christian understanding of Scripture is that persistent rejection of God and unrepentant sin have eternal consequences.

Therefore, the warning against the way of sinners is serious.

The virtuous person does not treat sin as harmless simply because it is popular.

He understands that God's judgment is real.

This produces not merely fear, but **wisdom and repentance**.

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10. “Nor Sat in the Chair of Pestilence”

The third warning is:

“Nor sat in the chair of pestilence.”

Many English translations render the final expression with words such as **“seat of scoffers”** or **“seat of the scornful.”**

The picture is of a person who has moved beyond merely hearing ungodly ideas or participating in sinful behavior.

He has now **sat down**.

He has become settled.

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11. Who Are the Mockers?

Mockers are people who ridicule or treat with contempt what they consider foolish.

In the spiritual context of Psalm 1, the mocker represents a person who **ridicules righteousness and rejects God's ways**.

Mockery can take different forms.

A person may mock:

- faith;
- prayer;
- Scripture;
- obedience;
- holiness;
- repentance;
- Christian values;
- a person's devotion to God.

The mocker may attempt to make faith appear foolish or unnecessary.

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12. Mockers Can Attack the Faith of the Virtuous Person

A virtuous person may experience ridicule because he chooses to live according to God's commandments.

People may say:

“Why do you take your faith so seriously?”

Or:

“You are too religious.”

Or:

“Everyone else does this. Why don't you?”

The goal of mockery can be to make the faithful person ashamed of obedience.

But Psalm 1 teaches the virtuous person not to allow mockery to determine his faithfulness.

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13. Do Not Let Mockery Control You

The virtuous person does not need the approval of mockers.

His standard is not:

“What will people think about me?”

His standard is:

“What does God require of me?”

This is an important aspect of spiritual courage.

A person who follows God will sometimes be misunderstood.

He may sometimes be criticized.

He may sometimes be mocked.

But the virtuous person does not abandon righteousness simply because someone laughs at him.

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14. Walk, Stand, Sit — A Spiritual Progression

One of the most memorable features of Psalm 1:1 is its progression:

Walk → Stand → Sit

First: Walk

“walked in the counsel of the ungodly”

The person begins by **listening to ungodly counsel**.

Second: Stand

“stood in the way of sinners”

The person becomes involved in the **way or conduct of sinners**.

Third: Sit

“sat in the chair of pestilence”

The person becomes **settled among mockers**.

The movement is:

Influence → Participation → Identification

What begins as listening can eventually become living.

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15. The Battle Begins in the Mind

Psalm 1 begins with **counsel** because spiritual compromise often begins with thinking.

Before a person follows a sinful path, he often first accepts an idea.

The pattern can be:

Idea → belief → decision → action → habit → character

Therefore, guarding one's mind is extremely important.

This is why Scripture repeatedly emphasizes wisdom, discernment, truth, and meditation on God's Word.

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16. The Virtuous Person Practices Discernment

The virtuous person does not reject every person who disagrees with him.

Rather, he practices **discernment**.

He examines counsel.

He tests ideas.

He considers consequences.

He compares teaching with God's Word.

He asks:

Is this true?

Is this righteous?

Will this draw me closer to God or away from Him?

This is biblical wisdom.

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17. Psalm 1 Does Not Teach Isolation

Psalm 1 should not be understood as commanding believers to have no contact with anyone who is sinful or ungodly.

Everyone is a sinner in need of God's grace.

The warning concerns **participation in and adoption of ungodly ways**.

The virtuous person can interact with people without allowing their sinful values to become his own.

The issue is not simply:

“Who is around me?”

The deeper question is:

“Whose counsel am I accepting, whose way am I following, and whose values am I adopting?”

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18. The Positive Alternative — Psalm 1:2

Psalm 1:1 tells us what the blessed person rejects.

Psalm 1:2 tells us what he embraces:

“But his will is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he shall meditate day and night.”

This is the turning point.

The virtuous person does not merely remove bad influences.

He replaces them with **God's Word**.

He does not merely reject ungodly counsel.

He seeks **God's wisdom**.

He does not merely leave the way of sinners.

He chooses **the way of righteousness**.

He does not merely leave the seat of mockers.

He finds his delight in **the law of the Lord**.

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19. From Ungodly Counsel to God's Counsel

Psalm 1 presents two sources of direction.

Ungodly counsel

It can mislead.

God's law

It gives righteous instruction.

The blessed person therefore asks:

“Whose counsel will govern my life?”

The answer of Psalm 1 is clear:

God's Word.

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20. From the Way of Sinners to the Way of the Righteous

There are two ways.

The way of sinners

It leads toward judgment and ultimately perishes.

The way of the righteous

It is known by the Lord.

Psalm 1:6 provides the conclusion:

“For the Lord knoweth the way of the just: and the way of the wicked shall perish.”

The choice of the way is therefore a matter of eternal significance.

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21. From the Seat of Mockers to the Presence of God

The mocker sits among those who ridicule righteousness.

The righteous person instead delights in God's law.

The contrast is profound:

Seat of mockers
versus
delight in God's Word

One environment encourages contempt for God.

The other produces love for God's truth.

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22. The Blessed Person Is Like a Tree

Psalm 1:3 gives the result:

“And he shall be like a tree which is planted near the running waters…”

The tree represents:

- stability;
- nourishment;
- life;
- fruitfulness;
- endurance;
- spiritual growth.

The blessed person has roots.

Why?

Because his life is nourished by God's Word.

He is not easily moved by every opinion.

He is not redirected by every temptation.

He is not destroyed by every criticism.

He is rooted.

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23. A Life of Fruitfulness

Psalm 1:3 continues:

“That shall bring forth its fruit, in due season…”

The purpose of a healthy tree is fruitfulness.

Likewise, the purpose of a righteous life is spiritual fruit.

The blessed person does not merely avoid sin.

He produces good fruit.

His life should increasingly display:

- righteousness;
- wisdom;
- obedience;
- love;
- faithfulness;
- self-control;
- mercy;
- perseverance.

The blessed life is therefore **productive**, not merely defensive.

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24. A Practical Application

Psalm 1:1 gives us three questions to ask ourselves.

Question 1: Whose counsel am I accepting?

Are the voices influencing me consistent with God's truth?

Question 2: What way am I following?

Are my repeated choices taking me toward righteousness or toward sin?

Question 3: Where am I sitting?

Have I become comfortable among people or environments that continually mock God and righteousness?

These questions help us examine the direction of our lives.

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25. The Central Lesson

Psalm 1:1 teaches that the virtuous person must guard three things:

His Mind

He does not accept **ungodly counsel**.

His Conduct

He does not follow **the way of sinners**.

His Fellowship

He does not settle among **mockers**.

And Psalm 1:2 provides the positive foundation:

His Delight

He delights in **the law of the Lord**.

His Meditation

He meditates upon God's Word **day and night**.

The result is a life like:

“a tree planted near the running waters.”

Conclusion

Psalm 1:1 presents the beginning of the blessed life by teaching us what the virtuous person refuses to follow.

He does not allow **ungodly people to determine his counsel**.

He does not follow **the way of sinners**.

He does not allow **mockers to shame him out of his faith**.

The progression is striking:

He does not walk in ungodly counsel.
He does not stand in the way of sinners.
He does not sit among mockers.

The movement is:

Walk → Stand → Sit
Counsel → Way → Seat
Influence → Participation → Identification

But Psalm 1 does not leave the virtuous person with an empty life.

Instead, he turns toward God.

He delights in God's law.

He meditates upon God's Word.

And his life becomes like a tree planted beside living water.

The message of Psalm 1 is therefore not merely:

“Stay away from bad people.”

Its deeper message is:

Guard your mind from ungodly counsel, guard your conduct from the way of sin, guard your faith from the influence of mockers, and root your entire life in the Word of God.

That is the path presented by Psalm 1 as the **blessed way**.

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1. The Virtuous Person Keeps Away from Sinful Influence

The virtuous person carefully avoids sinful influences that can weaken his relationship with God. He does not deliberately place himself in environments where sinful behavior is constantly encouraged. By guarding his associations, he protects his spiritual life.

2. Purity of Thoughts

A virtuous person seeks to maintain **purity of thought**. He understands that what enters the mind can influence the heart, decisions, words, and actions. Therefore, he chooses influences that encourage truth, righteousness, wisdom, and holiness.

3. Humility of the Virtuous Person

The virtuous person is **humble**. He does not consider himself superior to others. He recognizes his dependence upon God and remains willing to receive correction and wisdom. True virtue is accompanied by humility rather than pride.

4. Humble Words

A virtuous person seeks to speak with **gentleness, respect, and humility**. His words are not intended to insult, dominate, or humiliate others. He understands that speech can either build a person up or cause harm.

5. Sin as a Spiritual “Virus”

Sin can be compared, as an illustration, to a **virus that corrupts a system**. Just as a computer virus can interfere with the proper functioning of a system, persistent sin can corrupt a person's thinking, desires, decisions, and behavior.

This comparison is an illustration, not a literal description of how sin operates.

6. Misguidance and Corruption

Ungodly influence can introduce false ideas into a person's thinking. If those ideas are repeatedly accepted, they can influence choices and eventually become sinful patterns of behavior.

Therefore, Psalm 1:1 begins with **counsel**. The person must guard what influences his thinking before those influences become actions.

7. Guarding the Mind

The virtuous person practices spiritual discernment. He asks whether the ideas, advice, and influences he receives are consistent with God's truth. In this way, he seeks to protect his thoughts from influences that could lead him toward sin.

8. From Purity to Righteous Living

Purity of thought should lead to purity of conduct. The virtuous person does not merely think about righteousness; he seeks to live it through his words, decisions, relationships, and actions.

The principle is:

Guard the mind → purify the thoughts → speak humbly → choose righteousness → live faithfully before God.